

AP United States History:

The Complete Exam Guide

All 9 periods explained, the SAQ, DBQ and LEQ playbook with a sample thesis, the historical thinking skills, and 10 hard source-based practice questions.

Hi, I'm **Pigo!** I'll drop tips all through this guide.

**3:15**

hours total,
including reading time

55+5

multiple-choice +
written questions

25%

of your score is
the DBQ alone

74%

scored 3 or higher
in recent years

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THE EXAM AT A GLANCE

Two sections, four tasks

Your AP score (1–5) combines multiple choice, short answers and two essays. Most tasks are source-based, covering American history from 1491 to the present.

40%

MCQ • 55 questions

20%

SAQ • 3 questions

25%

DBQ • 1 essay

15%

LEQ

Exam structure

Section	Weight & timing	What you do
IA • Multiple choice	40% of score 55 minutes 55 questions	Sets of usually 3–4 questions built around a primary or secondary source: texts, images, charts or maps.
IB • Short answer	20% of score 40 minutes 3 questions	Q1 (secondary source or sources) and Q2 (primary source) are required; then choose Q3 or Q4 (no source). Each has three parts.
II • Document-based question	25% of score 60 min (incl. 15-min reading) 1 essay	Write an argument using 7 documents plus your own knowledge. The DBQ covers 1754–1980.
II • Long essay	15% of score 40 minutes 1 essay	Choose one of three prompts, each covering a different span of time periods, and write an argument.

FULLY DIGITAL

Everything happens in Bluebook

You answer every question, including the written responses, in College Board's **Bluebook** testing app. Responses are submitted automatically at the end. Practice typing timed answers before May.

SCORED WITH RUBRICS

Essays use the same rubric every year

The DBQ (7 points) and long essay (6 points) are scored on thesis, contextualization, evidence and analysis. Learning the rubric is the fastest way to raise your score.

How to use this guide

Just starting?

Read pages 2–6, then follow the roadmap on page 8 month by month.

Mid-year?

Check the traps on page 7 and drill the free-response playbook on page 6.

Exam in weeks?

Take the 10 questions on page 9 in 15 minutes, then use the final-four-weeks plan.

SECTION I

02 Multiple choice & short answer

55 multiple-choice questions in 55 minutes (one minute each), then 3 short-answer questions in 40 minutes. Most questions use a source.

55

source-based multiple-choice questions

1:00

minute per multiple-choice question

3

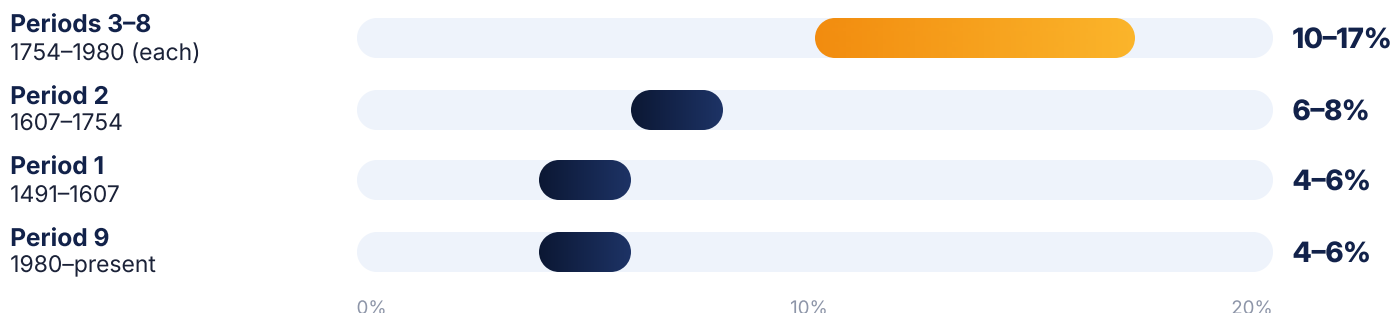
short-answer questions, 3 parts each

0

points lost for a wrong answer, so never leave one blank

How the exam is weighted by period

College Board gives a range for each period's share of the exam. Bars show minimum to maximum.

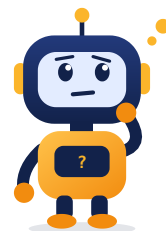


What this means for your study time: Periods 3–8 (1754–1980) each carry 10–17% and together make up most of the exam. The first two and the last period are much smaller.

Strategies for multiple choice and short answers

- **Read the source line first:** author, date and audience tell you the context before you read the text.
- **Answer the question asked.** "Which development most directly caused..." means a cause, not just a related event.
- **For short answers, use ACE:** Answer the question, Cite specific evidence, Explain how it supports your answer.
- **One part, one paragraph.** Label each short-answer part (a), (b), (c) and answer in 2–3 sentences.
- **Be specific:** name people, laws, events and dates. Vague answers rarely earn the point.
- **Never leave a blank.** Guess, flag and move on at the one-minute mark.

Short answers need **specific evidence**. "There were reforms" scores nothing; naming one reform can.



03 WHAT THE COURSE COVERS

The 9 periods, in plain English

Everything on the exam fits into these periods.

PERIOD 1 4–6%	1491–1607 Know: Native American societies before contact; the Columbian Exchange; Spanish colonization and the encomienda system.	PERIOD 2 6–8%	1607–1754 Know: differences between colonial regions; Atlantic trade and slavery; mercantilism; the Great Awakening and Enlightenment ideas.
PERIOD 3 10–17%	1754–1800 Know: the Seven Years' War; causes and effects of the Revolution; Articles of Confederation; the Constitution and the first party system.	PERIOD 4 10–17%	1800–1848 Know: Jeffersonian and Jacksonian democracy; the market revolution; the Second Great Awakening and reform; Indian Removal.
PERIOD 5 10–17%	1844–1877 Know: Manifest Destiny and the Mexican-American War; sectional crisis; the Civil War; Reconstruction and its end.	PERIOD 6 10–17%	1865–1898 Know: industrialization and big business; immigration and urbanization; the Gilded Age; labor unions; Populism and the West.
PERIOD 7 10–17%	1890–1945 Know: imperialism; the Progressive Era; World War I; the 1920s; the Great Depression and New Deal; World War II.	PERIOD 8 10–17%	1945–1980 Know: the Cold War and containment; the civil rights movement; the Great Society; Vietnam; social movements and the rise of conservatism.
PERIOD 9 4–6%	1980–present Know: the Reagan era; the end of the Cold War; globalization and technology; debates over the role of government; responses to terrorism.		

◆ The historical thinking skills

Sourcing

Analyze point of view, purpose, audience and situation.

Contextualization

Place an event in its broader historical setting.

Comparison

Explain similarities and differences.

Causation & CCOT

Explain causes, effects, continuity and change.

SECTION II

04 The DBQ & the long essay

100 minutes for two essays. Both are scored with fixed rubrics, so you can practice for exactly what earns points.

Thesis 1

Context 1

Evidence 3

Analysis & reasoning 2

DBQ rubric: 7 points. The long essay uses the same rows but 2 evidence points (6 in total).

DBQ

Document-based question

7 points • 60 minutes

Use at least **4 documents** to support an argument for full evidence credit, add one piece of **outside evidence**, and explain **sourcing** for at least 2 documents.

Group documents into 2–3 categories that each prove part of your thesis.

LEQ

Long essay question

6 points • 40 minutes

No documents: the evidence comes from your own knowledge. Choose the prompt carefully, then argue a clear line of reasoning.

Pick the prompt for which you know the most specific evidence.

Th

Thesis (1 point)

Historically defensible claim

One or two sentences that make a claim and set out a line of reasoning. It can be in the introduction or conclusion.

"Although X, Y mainly because A and B" shows complexity from the start.

Cx

Contextualization (1 point)

The bigger picture

Describe broader developments before, during or after the period that relate to the prompt, in several sentences.

Write it as your opening paragraph so you don't forget it.

◆ A time plan for the 100 minutes

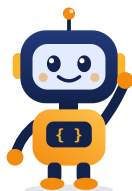
Read docs
15 min

Write DBQ
45 min

Plan
LEQ
5 min

Write LEQ
35 min

The 15-minute reading period is built into the recommended 60 minutes for the DBQ.



The **complexity point** is the hardest. Earn it by analyzing multiple variables, qualifying your argument, or connecting across periods.

05 FREE-RESPONSE PLAYBOOK

Anatomy of a strong DBQ

Here is a DBQ-style prompt, a strong opening and one body paragraph, annotated to show where points come from.

PRACTICE TASK • WRITTEN BY ACT SAT GO

Practice prompt (DBQ style): Evaluate the extent to which the Progressive movement changed the role of the federal government in American life from 1890 to 1920. (*Sample paragraph references hypothetical documents.*)

Sample opening and body paragraph

① By the 1890s, rapid industrialization had created vast corporations, crowded cities and dangerous workplaces, while Gilded Age governments largely followed laissez-faire policies.

② **Thesis:** The Progressive movement greatly expanded the federal government's role as a regulator of the economy and protector of consumers, although it did far less to protect the rights of African Americans and immigrants.

③ Muckraking exposed abuses that pushed Congress to act. Document 3, an excerpt from a novel about the meatpacking industry, shocked readers with descriptions of unsanitary factories. ④ Because the author was a socialist hoping to win sympathy for workers, he emphasized harsh conditions, yet readers reacted mostly to the threat to their food. ⑤ That outrage helped pass the Meat Inspection Act and the Pure Food and Drug Act in 1906, bringing federal inspectors into private industry.

- ① **Contextualization** sets up the broader situation before the thesis.
- ② **Thesis** makes a defensible claim with a line of reasoning.
- ③ **Document evidence** is used to *support* a point, not just summarized.
- ④ **Sourcing** explains why the author's purpose or point of view matters.
- ⑤ **Outside evidence** adds a specific fact not in the documents.

◆ Five habits for every history essay

- 1** Underline every task verb in the prompt before you plan.
- 2** Write a defensible thesis in your first paragraph.
- 3** Back every claim with specific evidence, then explain it.
- 4** Keep 2 minutes to reread and fix unclear sentences.
- 5** Stuck? Answer each part separately in order. Partial credit is real.

06 LEARN FROM OTHERS

10 traps that cost points

Meet **Glitch**. He lives in these ten mistakes. Squash each one before May.

Just **summarize** each document! (Don't.)



01 Restating the prompt as a thesis

A thesis must take a position and give reasons. Repeating the question earns no point.

02 Listing documents

"Document 1 says... Document 2 says..." is summary. Use documents as evidence for your argument.

03 Sourcing by labeling

"The author is a merchant" isn't enough. Explain **how** that affects the document's message.

04 One-sentence context

Contextualization needs several sentences about the broader situation, connected to the prompt.

05 Outside evidence from the documents

Outside evidence must be a specific fact that is **not** in any document.

06 Wrong time period

Evidence from outside the prompt's dates doesn't count. Check the years before writing.

07 Vague SAQ answers

Short answers need a specific example and an explanation, not a general statement.

08 Running out of time on the DBQ

Watch the clock. A rushed LEQ costs more than a slightly shorter DBQ.

09 Presentism

Judge events by their own time's context, and avoid "always" or "never" claims.

10 Skipping the conclusion

A conclusion is a second chance to state the thesis or earn the complexity point.

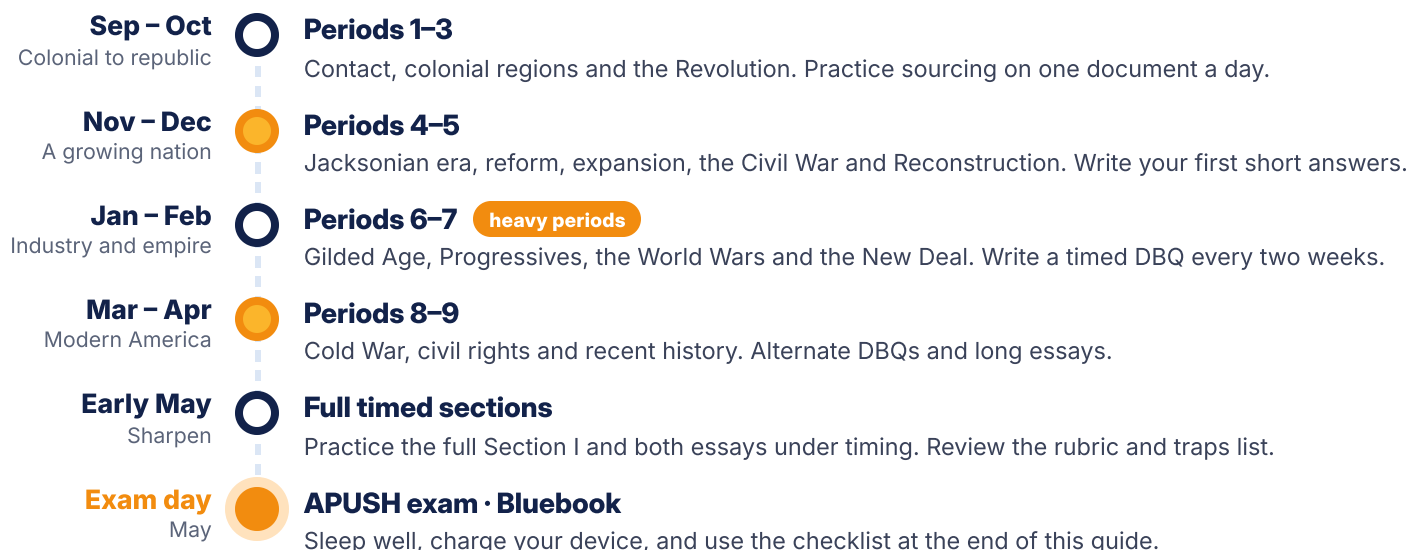
Quick self-check: could you explain, in two sentences each, one cause and one effect of the market revolution, the Compromise of 1877 and the Great Society? If not, those are periods to review.



PLAN YOUR YEAR

Your study roadmap to May

A steady plan beats a last-minute rush. Shift the months to match your teacher's pacing, and write at least one timed essay every two weeks.



• The final four weeks

Week	Focus	Target
4 weeks out	Diagnose: one timed DBQ plus 28 multiple-choice questions	List your two weakest periods
3 weeks out	Review weak periods; write one SAQ set daily	Specific evidence in every answer
2 weeks out	Full 3-hour-15-minute practice exam	Finish all four tasks on time
Final week	Light review: rubric, key turning points, traps list	Rest the night before

08 TEST YOURSELF

10 practice questions

Original source-based questions written by ACT SAT GO in the style of the exam, pitched at the harder end. Give yourself **15 minutes** for all ten, then check page 11.

1 PERIOD 3 · SOURCING

"...That whenever any Form of Government becomes destructive of these ends, it is the Right of the People to alter or to abolish it, and to institute new Government..."

Declaration of Independence, 1776

The ideas expressed in the excerpt most directly reflect the influence of which of the following?

- A The First Great Awakening's emphasis on emotional religion
- B Mercantilist theories of colonial trade
- C Enlightenment theories of natural rights and the social contract
- D The Articles of Confederation's weak central government

2 PERIOD 3 · CAUSATION

Which development most directly increased tensions between Britain and its North American colonies after 1763?

- A The arrival of the first enslaved Africans in Virginia
- B The Louisiana Purchase
- C The ratification of the Constitution
- D British efforts to tax the colonies to pay debts from the Seven Years' War

3 PERIOD 4 · COMPARISON

The Second Great Awakening and the abolitionist movement were similar in that both:

- A promoted the idea that individuals and society could be perfected
- B were led mainly by Southern planters
- C opposed women's participation in public life
- D aimed mainly to expand westward settlement

4 PERIOD 5 · CONTINUITY & CHANGE

Which best describes a **continuity** in the South from before the Civil War through the end of Reconstruction?

- A Slavery remained legal
- B Agriculture based on cotton remained central to the economy
- C African American men could not vote
- D Southern states remained outside the Union

5 PERIOD 6 · CAUSATION

The rise of large labor unions such as the Knights of Labor in the late 1800s was most directly a response to:

- A the closing of the frontier
- B the end of Reconstruction
- C long hours, low wages and unsafe conditions in industrial workplaces
- D the Federal Reserve's control of the money supply

08 TEST YOURSELF (continued)

6 PERIOD 7 · ARGUMENTATION

Which piece of evidence best supports the claim that the New Deal permanently expanded the federal government's role in the economy?

- A The Civilian Conservation Corps ended in 1942
- B Social Security continued to provide benefits long after the 1930s
- C The Supreme Court struck down the NRA in 1935
- D Unemployment remained high until World War II

7 PERIOD 7 · SOURCING

A 1919 cartoon shows a figure labeled "Uncle Sam" sweeping away people labeled "anarchist" and "Bolshevik" while new immigrants wait at a dock.

Description of a political cartoon, 1919

The cartoon most directly reflects which development?

- A The First Red Scare and rising nativism after World War I
- B The Progressive Era's support for unrestricted immigration
- C The isolationism of the Neutrality Acts
- D Support for the League of Nations

8 PERIOD 8 · CAUSATION

Which was a major effect of the Supreme Court's decision in *Brown v. Board of Education* (1954)?

- A It immediately ended segregation in all Southern schools
- B It guaranteed voting rights for all African Americans
- C It created the Equal Employment Opportunity Commission
- D It overturned the "separate but equal" doctrine of *Plessy v. Ferguson* for public schools

9 PERIOD 8 · CONTEXTUALIZATION

The policy of containment adopted after 1947 is best understood in the context of:

- A the end of the Great Depression
- B the rise of the Populist Party
- C American fears that Soviet communism would expand into Europe and Asia
- D the closing of the Western frontier

10 PERIOD 9 · COMPARISON

Supporters of Ronald Reagan's economic policies in the 1980s most often argued that:

- A government spending on social programs should greatly expand
- B tax cuts and deregulation would encourage growth
- C tariffs should be raised to protect industry
- D the gold standard should be restored



CHECK YOUR WORK

Answer key & explanations

Read every explanation, even for questions you got right. Each one points to a pattern that keeps coming back on the exam.

#	Answer	Why
1		The right to "alter or abolish" a government that violates natural rights comes from Enlightenment thinkers such as John Locke and the social contract.
2		Debt from the Seven Years' War led Parliament to pass the Sugar, Stamp and Townshend Acts, provoking "no taxation without representation" protests.
3		Both drew on the belief that people could reform themselves and society; many abolitionists were inspired by revivalist religion.
4		Slavery ended and Black men gained the vote (for a time), but the Southern economy stayed rooted in cotton, now through sharecropping.
5		Unions formed to fight the long hours, low pay and dangerous conditions created by rapid industrialization.
6		Social Security's long-term survival shows lasting federal involvement. The other choices show programs ending, limits on the New Deal or its shortfalls.
7		After World War I, fear of radicals and immigrants (the First Red Scare) led to raids, deportations and immigration restrictions in the 1920s.
8		<i>Brown</i> ruled school segregation unconstitutional, overturning <i>Plessy</i> for schools. Desegregation itself was slow and resisted.
9		Containment, set out in the Truman Doctrine, aimed to stop Soviet expansion after World War II, a defining policy of the Cold War.
10		Supply-side economics argued that lower taxes and less regulation would spur investment and growth that benefited everyone.

9–10

Strong. Move on to full timed free-response practice.

6–8

On track. Revisit the unit behind every miss on page 4.

0–5

Build foundations now. Re-learn the turning points of each period and practice sourcing.

10 KNOW THE TARGET

How students score

In recent years, about 74% of students earned a 3 or higher on AP United States History, and about 14% earned a 5. Steady preparation is what moves a score up a full point.

74%

of students earned a 3 or higher in recent years

14%

earned the top score of 5 in recent years

3+

is the score many colleges accept for credit or placement

What each AP score means

5

Extremely well qualified

4

Very well qualified

3

Qualified

2

Possibly qualified

1

No recommendation

Ranges reflect recent College Board score distributions and shift a little each year. Credit and placement policies vary by college, so check each college's AP policy.

Exam-day checklist

- ☐ **Bluebook** is installed and updated, and your device passed the exam check
- ☐ Device **fully charged**, with the charger packed
- ☐ Admission ticket and photo ID, as your school requires
- ☐ Confirm your **exam day and start time** in May with your AP coordinator
- ☐ Plan your time: **1 min** per multiple-choice question, **~13 min** per short answer, **60 min** for the DBQ and **40 min** for the long essay
- ☐ Answer **every** multiple-choice question. Wrong answers don't lose points
- ☐ Memorize the **DBQ and LEQ rubric rows**
- ☐ Practice typing a full essay in 40 minutes before exam day

In the essays: open with context, state a defensible thesis with reasons, use documents as evidence with sourcing, add specific outside evidence, and explain how every piece supports your argument.



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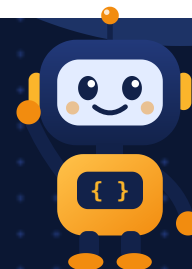
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